

Thinking about you

playful algorithm interaction on
personalised social media apps

Dr Andreas Schellewald



The slow decline of “social” media?



Economist 2024



Axios 2021



The End of Social Media and the Rise of Recommendation Media

Recommendation media is the new standard for content distribution. Here's why friend graphs can't compete in an algorithmic world.

Mignano 2022



Has the reign of social media ended?

Le Monde 2024



Financial Times 2025

TikTok and personalised social media

Content-centricity

(Kaye et al. 2022)

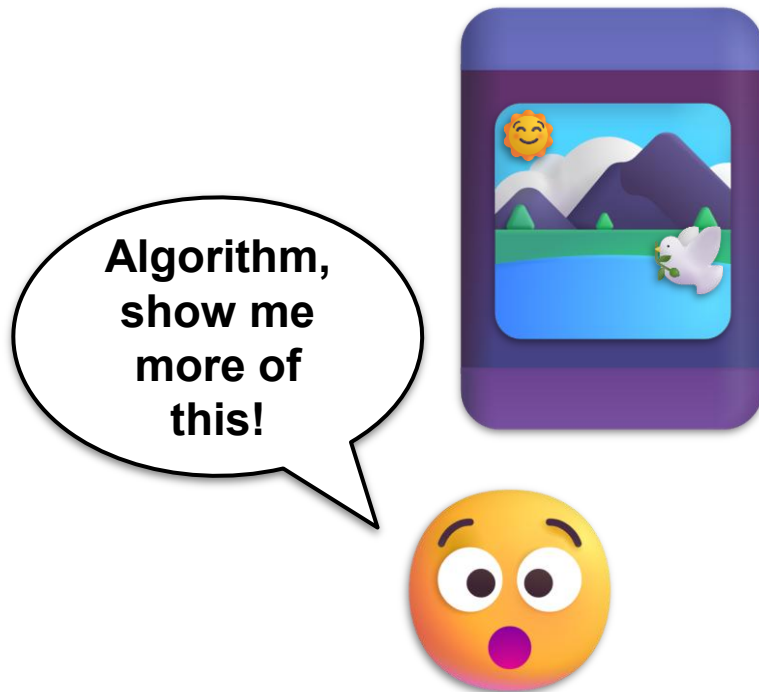
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Algorithm-centred design

(Su, 2023)

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The end of “social” media?



Where is the “social” in “social media”?

-  Media are not “**social**” by design but **through their social use** (Madianou and Miller 2012).
-  Using media to **enrich** existing relationships (Baym, 2010) or as **catalysts** for group interactions (Prior, 2014).
-  **Sensing** the presence of others in digital traces (Madianou, 2016), creating ephemeral **contextual awareness** (Bayer et al., 2016).
-  Algorithmic recommendations as **socio-cultural currency** in interaction (Siles, 2023), such as when sharing memes to **affirm relationships** and social status (McLean et al., 2023).

Methodology and Fieldwork



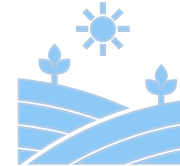
Digital Fieldwork

- Digital ethnography of TikTok, “For You” page.
- 6 months starting in early 2020.
- Daily routine of scrolling through the app for 30 to 60 mins.
- Content journal to explore new “sides” of TikTok via training algorithm and search.



Ethnography of TikTok Consumption

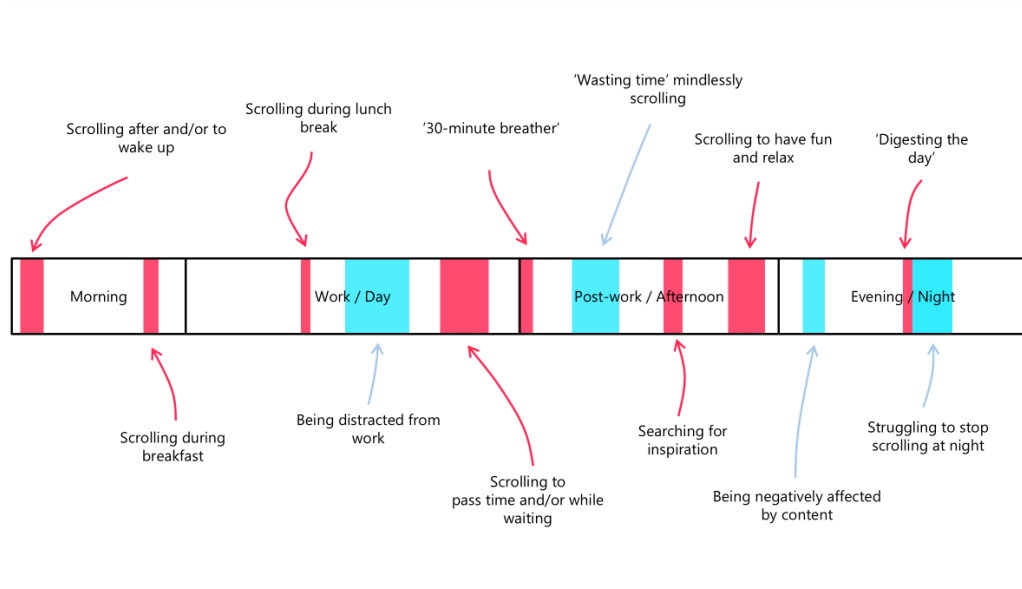
- Ethnographic study with 30 UK-based young adult TikTok users.
- 12 months starting in Summer 2020.
- Main data: semi-structured interviews at 3-month intervals.
- Additional: participant observations; media mapping; informal conversation.



Digital Fieldwork

- Digital ethnography of Instagram Reels.
- 14 months starting in late 2023.
- Focussed engagement with “share this” genre.
- Collecting 839 videos of the genre through trained Instagram algorithm.
- Thematic analysis (together with Yiting Wang, U of Hawaii).

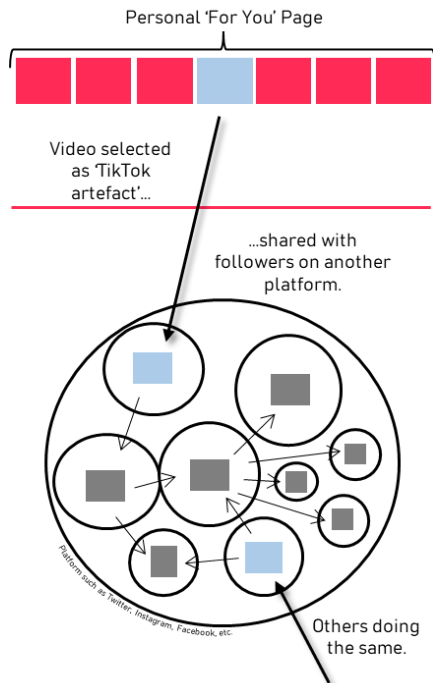
TikTok's role in everyday life



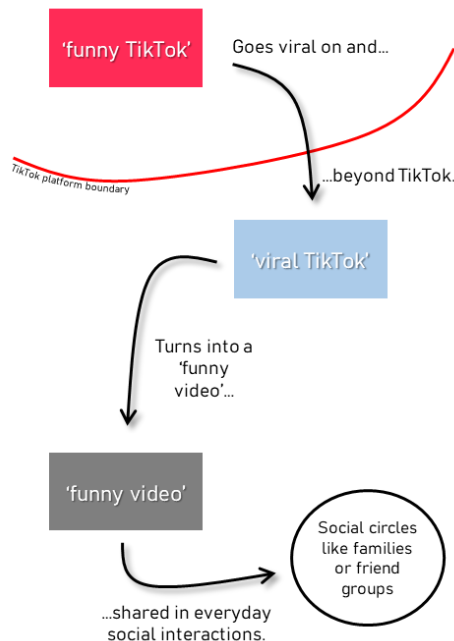
"I mean, it definitely has been an hour before [laughs] but it's normally twenty minutes or something, I think ... it might be like twenty minutes to half an hour, and then I'll send a few videos to my friends as well, like, you know ... I'll see one and think 'oh, that friend will find that funny' or 'this group of friends would find it funny'".

Three ways of how TikTok is shared

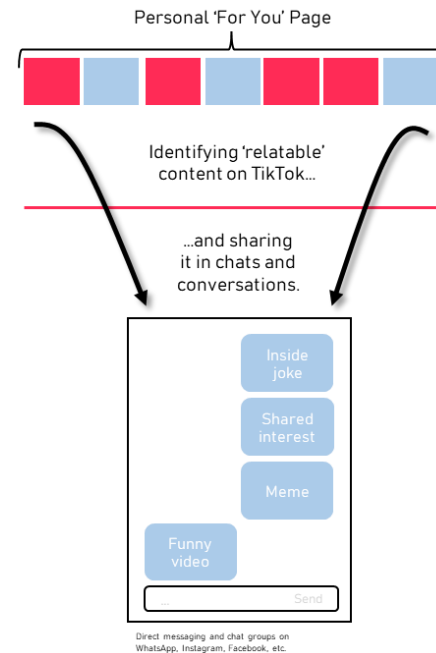
Direct personal to public

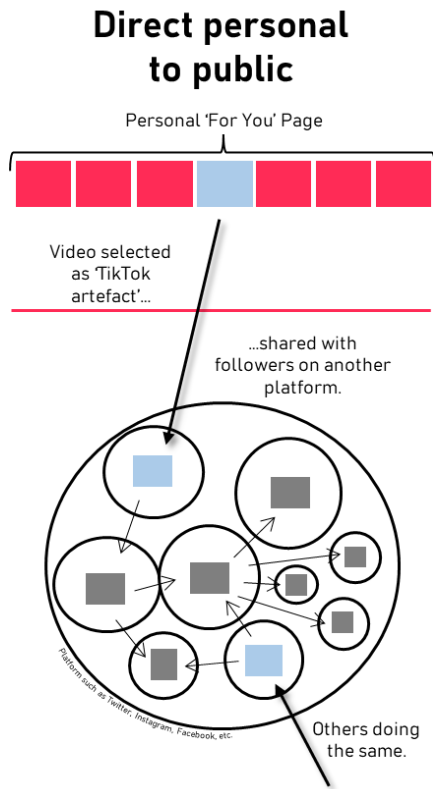


Indirect personal to social



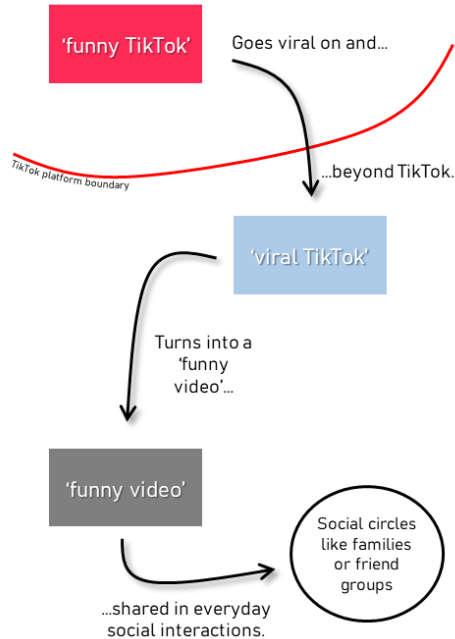
Direct personal to interpersonal





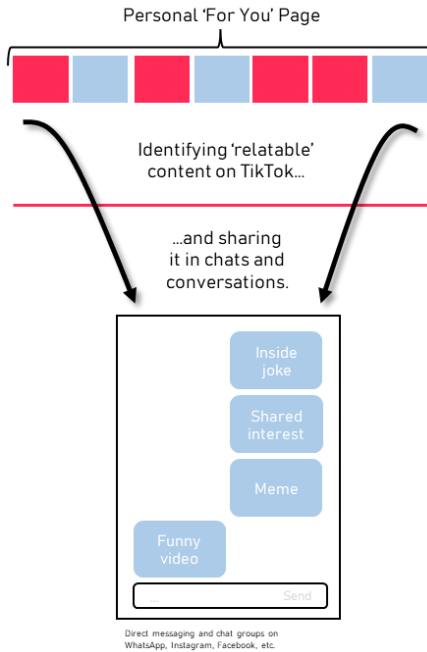
Hannes was a young journalists from London that I met during my fieldwork. He would talk about how often times when scrolling through TikTok, he'd come across videos that he'd share on other sites, like Twitter, with his followers to keep them informed, feeling that the content speaks to larger debates or topics of their interests, perspectives they should have.

Indirect personal to social



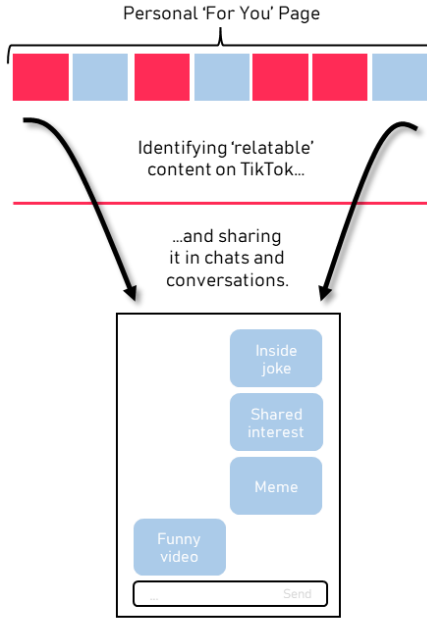
Mona, originally from Argentina, had lived in London for almost a decade by the time I met her. First to study and then to start her career as a freelancer in the advertising industry. Social media played a key role in her life staying in touch with her family and home country on the other side of the world. Her mother in particular would use the opportunity to share “funny videos” she received on WhatsApp to stay in touch with her children – doing so without often realising that her kids had seen the content already as it had initially originated on TikTok.

Direct personal to interpersonal

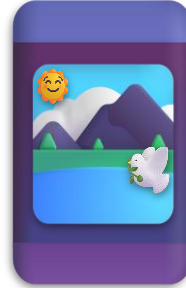


Antonio was a recent university graduate working for a big corporate office in London. He shares videos quite frequently with friends, either as direct messages or in a setting of physical co-presence. He talked about how he comes across content that is relatable, that conveys as a message “this is so you!”, simply will make them laugh by touching on inside jokes, or connecting to past conversations or memories they had – metacomunicating the message “I am thinning about you” in the act of sharing.

Direct personal to interpersonal



Direct messaging and chat groups on
WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, etc.

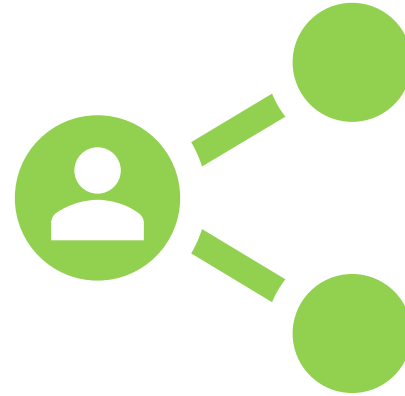


The first person in your
share list owes you a
holiday in the mountains!

The practice of sharing materialises increasingly in the vernacular on content-centric platforms. The “share this” genre of content crystallises a desire for social interaction in personalised media environments, playfully engaging with forms of digital touch and algorithmic sorting to articulate meaningfulness and intimacy online.

Atmospheric, ephemeral, algorithmically orchestrated sociability

- Personalised social media platforms provide cues (content) and opportunities (features) for interaction (social networks).
- Short content is easily convertible as a cultural resource. It is flexibly integrated into relations without dominating the interaction itself.
- Mobility of medium allows for physical co-consumption (at home and elsewhere).
- Algorithmic media literacy and ability to act on cues become crucial skills.



Playful social interactions and mediated intimacies

- Communication serves a self-fulfilling purpose of interaction (phatic / aesthetic function).
- Form and content of videos shared are used to affectively charge relationships (affection, longing, appreciation, tease).
- Social orderedness of interaction as equals, rules of what can be said / shared.
- Meaning emerges through the orderedness of interaction itself, it is in the play of the social that meaning is enacted.



Short-video content and algorithmic recommendations are paratexts

- Part of the continuous, **biographic dialogue** that defines the self through relationship with others.
- **Affective paratext**: continuous presence of distant others that are kept in mind / touch with through private, mobile media.
- **Symbolic paratext**: content that connects to past and present content of the interpersonal biography (references to memories, discussions, shared interests that tie together).



The sympotic rituals of personalised social media

- Sociability online is an increasingly **performative, playful, and regulated form of intimacy** that sustains social bonds and order (Pfeiffer 2023, Simmel 1910).
- “Traditional” social domains (e.g., **friends, family**) provide **the relational infrastructure** that makes personalized media emotionally significant (Madianou and Miller 2012).
- Content sharing function as **social catalyst** (McLean 2023) and **cultural capital**, demonstrating one's fluency in navigating digital sociality (Siles 2023), creating new challenges for social inclusion.
- **Commodification** of the “stuff” around which emotional intimacies are expressed. Remediating dynamics we have seen in cases like Hallmark and greeting card industry in US before (West 2008).



Thanks!

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